law firm LawQuest, also sees a stark departure from earlier policy. "Previously, checks were random or suspicion-based," she says. "Now they're mandatory for all student visas."

However, things aren't easy even for those who manage to secure visas. They face constant scrutiny: US agency Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) now wants students to show proof of full-time enrolment and perfect attendance, with deportation a looming consequence for any slip. Pablo S. Bose, professor of Geography and Geosciences and associate dean of research and graduate education at the University of Vermont, points out how Trump's crackdown is not restricted to new enrolments. The administration has revoked more than 300 visas, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio claiming the real figure may be in the thousands. Many of the students are targeted for presumed links to pro-Palestinian activism or alleged online support for 'terrorism'. Another 5,000 students have been expelled for minor infractions, ranging from underage drinking to traffic violations.

"All these measures affect who universities can host, whether current students can stay, and if graduates can work," says Bose. "The confusion and anxiety created have already had disastrous consequences." The mood of many Indian students enrolled in the US is one of fear and extreme caution, with most keeping a low profile and staying informed. Lubaina Kapasi, 19, a sophomore at the Savannah College of Arts, a private university in Georgia, has so far not felt the full brunt of the clampdown on international students compared to those studying in some public universities in the US. Yet, she says, "It doesn't mean we are fully in the clear. International students, especially from India, give up a lot financially and personally to study here. To then be faced with policy uncertainty and visa complications feels like a nightmare."

Legal recourse is limited as the US State Department is immune to visa denial lawsuits under the doctrine of consular non-reviewability

THE POLITICS OF IT

The Trump administration's clampdown on international students has been cast as a matter of national security, yet it reeks of a very different, cultural, battlefield. It stems from a desire to police campus discourse, with the administration viewing many universities as excessively "left-wing" and failing to curb pro-Palestinian activism, which it flatly equates with antisemitism or support for terrorism. Officially, the White House insists the heightened vetting is a "commonsense measure" to ensure newcomers pose no threat. "It's a privilege, not a right, to study in the United States," says White House spokesperson Anna Kelly.

ADVISORIES ON COMPLIANCE

The US embassy in India has issued advisories warning that students who skip classes, withdraw from programmes, or leave their studies without proper notification risk visa revocation. Indian students who fall afoul of these face deportation

PROPOSED CAP ON FOREIGN STUDENTS

President Trump has suggested capping foreign student enrolment at Harvard to 15 per cent, down from the current 31 per cent, arguing that they occupy seats wanted by Americans. If applied across varsities, the number of seats for Indians will fall steeply

REVOCATION OF SEVP CERTIFICATION

In May, Harvard's SEVP (Student and Exchange Visitor Program) certification that enables it to host foreign students was revoked for "fostering antisemitism and violence". A federal judge blocked this. Upheld and expanded elsewhere, Indians will be affected

FREEZING FEDERAL FUNDING

The US aims to leverage billions of dollars in federal grants to force US universities to bow to the agenda. For instance, it froze over $2.3 billion in research funding to Harvard. Quite a few Indians will be without funds if many top universities face funding cuts

DEMANDS FOR STUDENT INFORMATION

The administration has demanded that Harvard provide records of its foreign students, including disciplinary actions and coursework. Again, if expanded, students would be affected by this breach of academic freedom

TARGETING TECH STUDENTS

The administration wants to "aggressively revoke" visas of Chinese students, especially those linked to Communists or studying sensitive fields like AI and chip technology. This can lead to loss of talent in critical areas. If the net widens, Indians, too, can come under it

CLOSING THE OPT

In March, a bill was introduced in the US Congress to eliminate the Optional Practical Training (OPT) programme, which allows foreign students to work temporarily in the US after completing their studies. With a known OPT critic like Joseph Edlow being nominated as director of the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), many students fear missing out on work experience. As a result, some are considering alternative destinations too. French business schools, for instance, are fast-tracking admissions for students who have been affected by US visa restrictions